Chinese forces occupied a vacant post, crossed the Thagla Ridge (which had been a flashpoint in 1962), and built barracks and a helipad in the Sumdorong River valley. Indian forces under General Sundarji retaliated with an airlift to the heights overlooking the Chinese outpost, on Longrola and Hathungla, with forward posts ten metres from China's. Beijing was apparently taken aback by the Indian response, and was even more incensed when that same year, India decided to make Arunachal Pradesh a state. These developments led to greater tensions with China in 1986 and 1987, which were only resolved seven years later after Rajiv Gandhi's visit to Beijing in late 1988 and the upgrading of border talks in the early 1990s. [37]

Interventions: India's Neighbourhood, 1975–1990

The unambiguous success of the 1971 Bangladesh War presaged a period of considerable Indian interventionism in its near abroad. But as the dynamics of the Cold War crept in closer, India's activities were mostly relegated to its neighbourhood and extended into the Indian Ocean. Although India—along with Sri Lanka—had led proposals to make the Indian Ocean a zone of peace after 1970s, in practice, India was active in ensuring that it was dominated by neither the United States nor the Soviet Union. Indian military support extended to countries throughout the region, such as a 1973 deal for the Indian Navy to train its counterparts in Oman and an arrangement between the Indian Air Force and Iraq from the late 1960s to the Gulf War. [38]

But India's military role often took more direct forms. In 1983, in Mauritius, differences between political allies-turned-rivals Anerood Jugnauth and Paul Bérenger raised the prospect of political strife and potential violence. The tensions had begun to assume a sectarian character—ethnic Indians versus Creoles—and Jugnauth asked Indira Gandhi for military assistance. While the prime minister agreed to help militarily, the operation was put on hold, largely because of differences between the Army and Navy. Instead, diplomatic and intelligence efforts were successfully used to shore up Jugnauth's coalition and prevent a coup. [39] Three years